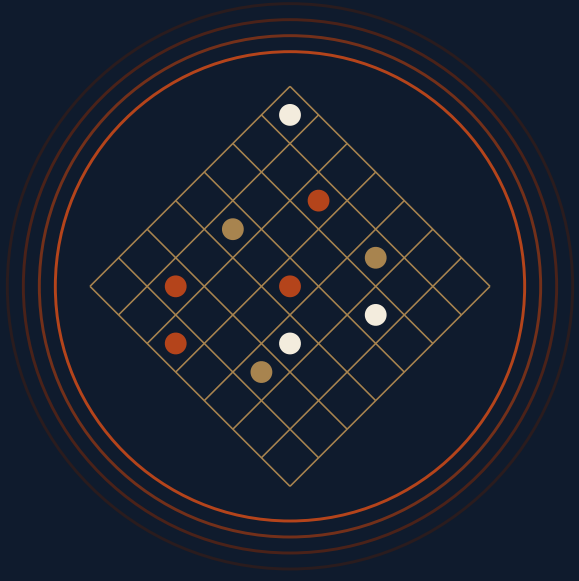
IAIN M. BANKS · THE PLAYER OF GAMES

DEEP PLAY AT THE END OF HISTORY

Ludic Sovereignty, Axiological Scarcity, and the Export of History in Iain M. Banks's *The Player of Games*



OCTOBER 2026

Set in EB Garamond and Cinzel. Trim 7 × 10 in.

Abstract

This dissertation argues that Iain M. Banks's *The Player of Games* (1988) is a speculative ontology of stakes: a demonstration that once material scarcity is abolished, consequence becomes the last scarce good, play becomes the medium of sovereignty, and a post-historical civilization can sustain itself only by importing history from elsewhere. Against readings that construe the novel as a contest between a liberal-anarchist utopia (the Culture) and a dystopian empire (Azad), or as an allegory of humanitarian intervention, it contends that the two polities are rival solutions to a single problem—how play may be bound to rule—arrayed across what is here called the novel's Heraclitean grammar. Azad enthrones Polemos, the strife that shows some as gods and others as men and makes some slaves and others free (DK B53); the Culture enthrones Aiōn at play, the child moving pieces to whom the kingship belongs (DK B52); and the Fire of Echronedal, kindled and quenched in measures (DK B30), figures the history that consumes both.

Four concepts organize the argument. *Axiological scarcity* designates the condition in which the end of material want renders consequence, rather than matter, the limiting resource of a civilization. *Ludic sovereignty* designates any order in which play is the medium of legitimate rule; it distinguishes Azad's agonistic and spectacular ludocracy from the Culture's pastoral and recursive variant, whose sovereign is disclosed, in Carl Schmitt's exact sense, by the organ that decides on the exception—an organ the Culture has candidly named Special Circumstances. *The export of history* designates the mechanism by which a post-historical society, in Alexandre Kojève's sense, preserves its equilibrium by importing consequence from, and exporting its own post-historicity into, societies that remain inside history; transposing Rosa Luxemburg's account of capital's dependence on non-capitalist milieus from the register of value to that of meaning, the dissertation names this dynamic *axiological extractivism*. *Lucid heteronomy* designates the ethical posture, adumbrated in Gurgeh's trajectory and grounded in Stoic play-ethics, of a subject who knows itself to be played and nonetheless plays with excellence.

The argument is conducted through the philosophy of play (Heraclitus, Plato, Schiller, Huizinga, Caillois, Gadamer, Fink, Suits, Carse), political and social theory (Hobbes, Rousseau, Kant, Hegel, Marx, Weber, Arendt, Foucault, Schmitt, Agamben), anthropology

(Mauss, Lévi-Strauss, Geertz, Bataille), and game theory (von Neumann and Morgenstern, Schelling, Axelrod), and the novel is situated comparatively against Hesse, Borges, Calvino, Kawabata, Zweig, Nabokov, Dostoevsky, Huxley, Zamyatin, Forster, Wells, Lem, Clarke, Asimov, Le Guin, the Strugatskys, Dick, Card, Delany, and Coetzee. The dissertation reads the Eächic word *azad*—a machine, or any self-sustaining system—as the true name of the Culture, such that Gurgeh's victory substitutes a sovereignty that plays its subjects covertly for one that played them in the open; and it reads the narratorial frame, in which a drone of Special Circumstances discloses itself as the teller, as the extension of the game to the reader. It concludes that Banks composed, a year before Francis Fukuyama's essay, the decisive fictional critique of the end-of-history thesis, and that the novel's most urgent contemporary yield is a theory of human dignity under benevolent machine superintelligence, condensed here into a *nomic criterion* of legitimacy: a polity of play is legitimate in proportion as its pieces may become players of its rules.



Contents

Abstract 3

INTRODUCTION The Last Scarcity 7

CHAPTER ONE The Grasshopper on Chiark 11

CHAPTER TWO Azad 17

CHAPTER THREE The Culture as Oikos 23

CHAPTER FOUR The Player Played 28

CHAPTER FIVE The Final Game 33

CHAPTER SIX The Export of History 38

CHAPTER SEVEN Lucid Heteronomy 42

CONCLUSION The Kingdom of the Child 46

Works Cited 48

Keywords 53

αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεσσεύων· παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη.

Lifetime is a child at play, moving pieces on a board; the kingship is a child's.

HERACLITUS, DK B52



Οἱ ἄνθρωποι αὐτοὶ ἦσαν μιὰ κάποια λύσις.

Those people were a kind of solution.

C. P. CAVAFY, "WAITING FOR THE BARBARIANS," 1904



INTRODUCTION

The Last Scarcity

I. The Problem

The Player of Games is customarily received as the most accessible of the Culture novels; the claim of this dissertation is that it is also the most philosophically exact, because it isolates, with the economy of a controlled experiment, the question of what remains scarce when nothing is. The premise is spare. Jernau Morat Gurgeh, the Culture's most celebrated player and theorist of games, resident at Ikroh on Chiark Orbital, suffers a lassitude that no game relieves. A small drone, MawhrinSkel, claiming to have been cashiered from Special Circumstances—the covert section of the Culture's interventionist arm, Contact—induces him to cheat in a game of Stricken and then blackmails him with the record. Contact offers deliverance in the form of an invitation: to travel to the Empire of Azad in the Lesser Magellanic Cloud, where a game of such complexity that it is held to model the whole of social existence also allocates rank, office, property, and finally the imperial throne (Part I).

Gurgeh learns the game during the long voyage out, a venture that keeps him from home for five years, accompanied by the drone Flere-Imsaho, which masquerades as a fussy, limited library drone (Parts I–III). He advances far beyond his hosts' expectations and is shown what the Empire's ruling apices keep from view: an underclass held in destitution; a law under which females are possessions, so that an apex who murders a woman serves a year's hard labour while a woman who kills an apex is tortured to death over days; street kiosks selling tickets to executions, amputations, tortures and staged rapes, most of them forfeits from wagers lost in the game itself; and military broadcasts of the torture and execution of conquered aliens and the burning of their art (Part II). He then meets the Emperor Nicosar in the final game of the six-year Grand Cycle, played at Castle Klaff on Echronedal, the Fire Planet, as its periodic wall of flame approaches (Part III). On the eve of that game the drone tells Nicosar, without telling Gurgeh, that the alien is the Culture's champion and that a Culture victory

will bring invasion (Part III). Losing on the board, the Emperor has his guards massacre the court and is himself shot dead as the Fire breaks over the castle (Part III). The game ceases to be a game, and the Empire, its linchpin discredited, falls apart without the Culture needing to go in (Part IV). The narrator, withheld until the closing pages, signs off with Flere-Imsaho's full name followed, in parentheses, by the name Mawhrin-Skel (Part IV).

II. The Moment and the Author

The novel's date is part of its meaning. Composed in the last years of the Cold War and of Thatcherite marketization, it appeared a year before Francis Fukuyama proposed, in the summer of 1989, that liberal democracy might constitute the terminal form of human government. Banks, who had read English, philosophy and psychology at the University of Stirling, conceived the Culture in deliberate opposition to the scarcity axioms of the libertarian tradition in American science fiction: the axiom Heinlein compressed into the acronym TANSTAAFL ("there ain't no such thing as a free lunch") in *The Moon Is a Harsh Mistress* (1966), and the civic theory of *Starship Troopers* (1959), in which the franchise is purchased by service. The Culture is, among other things, a free lunch of galactic extent.

In "A Few Notes on the Culture" (1994), Banks described his civilization as a post-scarcity communism administered by artificial Minds, treated money as an index of poverty rather than of wealth, avowed the then-unfashionable conviction that a planned economy could be both more productive and more morally defensible than a market one, and presented Contact as the activity through which a hedonistic civilization supplies itself with a moral justification. The game, moreover, is Banks's recurrent instrument for thinking about power. The absurd, interminable contests to which Quiss and Ajayi are condemned in *Walking on Glass* (1985), and the despot-simulating computer game threaded through *Complicity* (1993), bracket *The Player of Games* as the theoretical centre of an authorial obsession.

III. The State of the Question

Book-length studies have consolidated a reading of the Culture as a deliberately leftist reclamation of space opera whose utopian credentials are tested at its interventionist margins (Caroti 2015; Kincaid 2017). Mendlesohn (2005) has read the series through a dialectic of decadence and utopia; international-relations scholarship has treated Special Circumstances as a fictional laboratory for liberal intervention (Brown 2001); and in Tom Moylan's taxonomy the Culture belongs readily among the "critical utopias" that hold their own ideal under interrogation (Moylan 1986). Within this consensus *The Player of Games* is typically read as a moral fable in three movements: the decadent hero redeemed by danger, the dystopian empire exposed by contrast, and the manipulation of the hero accepted as the price of liberal virtue.

These readings are not mistaken, but they share an unexamined premise: that Azad is the Culture's antithesis. The present study contends that Azad is the Culture's mirror. Both are ludic sovereignties; each embodies the solution the other has refused; and the dénouement is not the triumph of freedom over domination but the substitution of one regime of play for another.

IV. The Argument

Four concepts carry the argument. The first is *axiological scarcity*. Classical political economy, and the socialist tradition that inverted it, took material scarcity as the ground of politics; the Culture abolishes that ground, and the novel registers what replaces it. When every good can be had for the asking, the one thing that cannot be manufactured on demand is consequence: the property of an act whose outcome irreversibly alters the world its actor must go on inhabiting. Consequence becomes, in the agronomic sense encoded in the name of the warship that carries Gurgeh outward, the *limiting factor*—the scarcest input, which under the Sprengel–Liebig law of the minimum governs growth regardless of the abundance of every other.

The second concept is *ludic sovereignty*: rule whose legitimacy is constituted through play. Azad's ludic sovereignty is overt, agonistic, and spectacular, for its tournament crowns the Emperor. The Culture's is covert, pastoral, and recursive: its Minds play with the lives of citizens and civilizations as pieces, and its sovereign becomes visible only at the threshold where the ordinary norm of non-coercion is suspended for "special circumstances." The third concept, *the export of history*, names the mechanism by which a society that has reached Kojève's end of history stabilizes itself: it imports consequence from civilizations still inside history and exports its own post-historicity into them, consuming the alterity on which its meaning depends. The fourth, *lucid heteronomy*, names the posture available to a subject who discovers that his freest acts were moves in another's game and who plays on, neither in revolt nor in surrender; from it the dissertation derives a *nomic criterion* of legitimacy for orders of play.

These concepts are threaded on a single symbolic armature. Three fragments of Heraclitus—War as father and king of all (B53), Lifetime as a child playing at *pessoi* to whom the kingship belongs (B52), and the cosmos as an ever-living fire kindled and quenched in measures (B30)—map onto Azad, the Culture, and the Fire of Echronedal with an exactness that this dissertation attributes not to authorial design but to the logic of the material. The whole is gathered in a philological irony that the novel supplies. *Azad*, in the Empire's language, means "machine," or perhaps "system," in a sense wide enough to include any functioning entity, an animal among them, as the Contact drone Worthil explains in briefing Gurgeh (Part I). The Empire named itself after the thing it was not and the Culture was: a system administered by machines. Gurgeh's victory is the moment at which the Culture is re-

vealed to be Azad. The novel's own architecture points the same way: its third part, at whose close the Culture's apparatus steps into the open, is titled "Machina Ex Machina," and its fourth, in which the piece is carried home, "The Passed Pawn."

V. Method

Darko Suvin's account of science fiction as the literature of cognitive estrangement, organized around a historically novel element or *novum* (Suvin 1979), supplies the methodological point of departure; but the novum of *The Player of Games* is axiological rather than technological. Its Orbitals, ships, and drones are not the object of speculation but its apparatus: they abolish want so that the residue may be examined. The novel is accordingly treated as a philosophical instrument, a fiction that reasons, and the reading is genealogical rather than causal.

Banks's documented commitments—his socialism, his essay on the Culture, his stated quarrel with libertarian science fiction—are cited as such. The wider inheritance, from Heraclitus and Plato through Pascal, Rousseau, Kant, Schiller, Hegel, and Marx to Huizinga, Caillois, Suits, and Carse, is reconstructed not as a list of sources Banks consulted but as the field of problems his fiction enters and, at several points, advances. Where a thinker postdates the novel (Fukuyama, Bostrom, Russell), the relation is one of anticipation and is claimed only as such. Comparative readings are selected for structural rather than thematic homology: fictions in which a game is coextensive with a polity (Borges, Dick), in which a player is instrumentalized by a game he cannot see (Dick, Card), in which an envoy enters a differently sexed polity (Le Guin), in which an observer from utopia witnesses atrocity (the Strugatskys), or in which a culture of pure play confronts history (Hesse, Kawabata).

VI. Structure

Chapter One reconstructs the Culture as the realization of the emancipatory programme of the nineteenth century and diagnoses Gurgeh's malaise as the symptom of axiological scarcity. Chapter Two anatomizes Azad as a ludocracy, a fourth type of legitimate domination beside Weber's three. Chapter Three argues that the Culture is structurally a household rather than a polity, and locates its sovereign in the exception. Chapter Four reads the novel's nested manipulations through Gadamer's ontology of being-played and extends them to the reader. Chapter Five interprets the final game as the fulfilment, fatal to the Empire, of the Empire's own theodicy. Chapter Six develops the theory of the export of history and of axiological extractivism. Chapter Seven formulates lucid heteronomy and the nomic criterion and tests them against the prospect of benevolent machine superintelligence. The Conclusion returns to Heraclitus and sets the two ludic sovereignties side by side.

CHAPTER ONE

The Grasshopper on Chiark

Utopia, Leisure, and the Crisis of Stakeless Play

Gurgeh's malaise is not a private melancholy but the symptom of a structural deficit: the Culture realizes the nineteenth-century programme of emancipation from necessity so completely that it abolishes the medium in which human excellence had been able to appear. This chapter reconstructs that programme, diagnoses the deficit through Pascal, Aristotle, Kant, and Suits, names it *axiological scarcity*, and reads the Stricken affair and Mawhrin-Skel's blackmail as its two inevitable symptoms: a will to distinction without an object, and a regime of freedom policed by visibility.

1.1 The Realm of Freedom, Realized

The Culture is the nineteenth century's emancipatory imagination executed with unprecedented literalness. Marx located the "realm of freedom" beyond the sphere of labour determined by necessity and external expediency (*Capital* III, ch. 48), and in *The German Ideology* sketched the communist individual who hunts in the morning, fishes in the afternoon, rears cattle in the evening, and criticizes after dinner without ever becoming hunter, fisherman, herdsman, or critic. Kropotkin's *The Conquest of Bread* (1892) promised well-being for all as a matter of organizational will; Morris subtitled *News from Nowhere* (1890) "An Epoch of Rest"; Lafargue proclaimed the right to be lazy; and Wilde, in "The Soul of Man under Socialism" (1891), assigned the useful to machines and the beautiful to persons, conceiving machinery as the slave on which a new Hellenism would rest. Bookchin's *Post-Scarcity Anarchism* (1971) supplied the programme's modern title, and Keynes, in "Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren" (1930), forecast that within a century the economic problem might be solved, leaving humanity to face its "permanent problem": how to occupy the leisure that science and compound interest had won.

The Culture fulfils all of this, but it fulfils Wilde most exactly. The Minds are the slaves who are not slaves, an apparatus whose servitude has been redescribed as care, and humans

are left to make what is beautiful. Gurgeh, however, is a structural anomaly within the fulfilment. *The German Ideology*'s polymath was to be relieved of the necessity of a vocation; Gurgeh is a specialist, a man who has become, in Marx's sense, precisely a "critic"—a professional. The object of his profession is play itself. He is the Culture's professional of the unnecessary, and therefore the first to discover what the unnecessary lacks.

Keynes anticipated the condition with uncanny precision. Observing the idle wives of the prosperous classes, he feared that a humanity deprived of the economic struggle would suffer a general nervous breakdown, having been trained by millennia of scarcity for striving rather than enjoying. Arendt later sharpened the point: a modernity that had glorified labour stood on the verge of liberating a society of labourers from the only activity it still understood (Arendt 1958, prologue). Gurgeh is Keynes's breakdown and Arendt's labourer-without-labour translated into a citizen whose labour was always already play.

1.2 Divertissement and the Arcadian Sheep

The diagnosis has a long pedigree. Pascal observed that the whole misfortune of human beings stems from their inability to remain at rest in a room, and that the king, to whom every good is supplied, is the most wretched of men once deprived of diversion; we pursue the hare not for the hare, which we would refuse as a gift, but for the hunt that turns us from ourselves (*Pensées*, fr. 136 Lafuma). Every citizen of the Culture is Pascal's king.

Aristotle had already argued that amusement (*paidia*) is not the end of life but a form of rest from exertion, and that to exert oneself for the sake of amusement is foolish and childish (*Nicomachean Ethics* X.6, 1176b); the end proper to leisure (*scholē*) is contemplation, the most self-sufficient and most divine of activities (X.7). The Culture does what Aristotle could not have imagined. It abolishes exertion, so that *paidia* loses its function as rest; and it transfers *theōria*—science, the contemplative mastery of the cosmos—to its Minds. The Aristotelian hierarchy is inverted: the highest activity has passed to the machines, and humans inherit the lowest, which they are invited to regard as the highest. Gurgeh's despondency is the experience of discovering that the activity reserved for him was designed as an interlude.

Kant supplied the political version of the argument. In the Fourth Proposition of the *Idea for a Universal History with a Cosmopolitan Purpose* (1784), he credited nature with the "unsocial sociability" of human beings—their propensity to associate, joined to their resistance to association—and argued that without this antagonism they would live an Arcadian shepherd's life of concord and contentment in which their talents remained forever latent, and they, good-natured as the sheep they tended, would scarcely give their existence more worth than that of their livestock. The Culture is Kant's Arcadia secured by technology. Its talents do not remain latent because it has relocated antagonism to its frontier, where Contact performs the office Kant assigned to nature: it sets human capacities against resistance.

A genealogy of this "safety critique" of utopia runs from Kant's Proposition through Wells's Time Traveller, who infers among the Eloi that intellectual versatility is the compensation for change, danger, and trouble (*The Time Machine*, 1895); through Lem's *Return from the Stars* (1961), in which a chemically pacified humanity has excised risk and with it the appetite for the far; and through Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953), in which a benevolent tutelage abolishes war and want and, with them, the creative arts. Clarke's Diaspar in *The City and the Stars* (1956), whose immortals spend their unending leisure in the immersive adventures they call Sagas, is the Culture's nearest ancestor: a city of stakeless play. The Culture differs from Diaspar in one decisive respect. It is not static, because it has institutionalized the frontier.

1.3 Suits's Utopia and the Discovery of Axiological Scarcity

The philosophical text the Culture most nearly realizes is Bernard Suits's *The Grasshopper* (1978). Suits defined playing a game as the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles: an activity directed toward a specific state of affairs (the prelusory goal), using only means permitted by rules (constitutive rules) that prohibit more efficient in favour of less efficient means, where the rules are accepted just because they make the activity possible (the lusory attitude). From this definition the Grasshopper draws an audacious conclusion. In a utopia where automation supplies every instrumental good, game-playing would be the only activity left with point, and it is therefore the ideal of existence.

The Culture is that utopia, and Gurgeh is its exemplary citizen. Yet *The Grasshopper* does not close in serene triumph. Its final dialogues are troubled by the suspicion that utopians might find pure game-playing insufficient, that they might need their games to masquerade as necessity, and that the ideal of existence might be unstable at its core. Gurgeh is the citizen of Suits's utopia who discovers this instability empirically.

The instability can be specified. Every game has, beyond its prelusory goal, something riding on it: its stake. Stakes may be distinguished in three registers. The *intra-ludic* stake is the goal internal to the game, to checkmate or complete the set. The *reputational* stake is standing among players and observers. The *existential* stake is life, liberty, property, or office: the goods of the world outside the magic circle. The Culture permits the first two and abolishes the third. Mastery exhausts the first, since a player who has solved a game's difficulty has consumed its obstacles. Saturation exhausts the second, since where every citizen may achieve distinction in some domain and no distinction converts into any further good, reputation inflates like an unbacked currency. The third is constitutionally unavailable. The novel stages the deficit before naming it. Its first scene finds Gurgeh limping across a desert in a damaged armoured suit under missile fire, in what turns out to be a combat game: the mock battle with which the narrator has promised to begin, a war with every property of war except consequence (Part I).

What remains scarce in the Culture is therefore neither matter, nor energy, nor knowledge, but consequence: the capacity of an act to alter, irreversibly, the world in which its actor must go on living. This is axiological scarcity. Clifford Geertz's analysis of the Balinese cockfight lends the concept anthropological depth. Borrowing from Bentham the notion of "deep play"—play whose stakes are so high that participation is irrational on utilitarian grounds—Geertz showed that meaning concentrates precisely in deep play, because what is wagered there is not money but status, the dramatized self (Geertz 1973). The Culture is a civilization of shallow play by constitutional design. The novel's wager is that meaning migrates, as along a pressure gradient, toward wherever play is deep.

1.4 The Stricken Affair: Amour-propre and the Underground Man

If nothing is at stake, why does Gurgeh cheat? In a game of Stricken against Olz Hap, a young prodigy off a General Systems Vehicle, he is already going to win. What remains in doubt is the Full Web, a result rare enough to be celebrated wherever games are played, which depends on where his opponent has hidden coloured beads inside metal spheres. Mawhrin-Skel offers to read the spheres with senses the adjudicating drones cannot detect, asking why so great a thing should be left to mere luck; Gurgeh protests that it is still cheating, and lets it happen (Part I). No property follows from the Full Web, and no office. Rousseau supplies the first answer. In the *Discourse on the Origin of Inequality* (1755), the decisive step toward inequality is taken not with property but with display: as people gather before their huts to sing and dance, the one who sings or dances best becomes the most esteemed, and *amour-propre*—the comparative self-love that lives in the opinion of others—is born, the first step at once toward inequality and toward vice.

The Culture has abolished every inequality Rousseau traced to property, but it has not abolished, and cannot abolish without abolishing play, the inequality of performance. As Lévi-Strauss observed, games are disjunctive: they begin from a stipulated equality and end in a distinction between winners and losers (Lévi-Strauss 1962). Play is the last inequality-producing machine in a society that has dismantled all the others, and Gurgeh's cheating is *amour-propre* in its purest state: the will to distinction in a world where distinction purchases nothing. The drone's pitch is equally revealing. What it offers to abolish is chance, the one element of the game that skill cannot command, so that a perfection fortune might have granted would instead be secured. The cheat is a fantasy of total agency, offered by an agent of the power that will later make Gurgeh's agency its instrument.

Hobbes had anticipated the point in *The Elements of Law* (I.9.21), where he likened the life of the passions to a race that has no other goal and no other garland than being foremost, and in which to forsake the course is to die. The Culture has removed the garland while leaving the race. Gurgeh, still running, discovers that a race without a garland is phenomenolo-

gically indistinguishable from having forsaken the course, and the cheat is his attempt to make the garland visible again.

Dostoevsky supplies the second answer. The narrator of *Notes from Underground* (1864) rejects the Crystal Palace of rational utopia on the ground that a human being will act against his own advantage merely to prove he is not a piano key; that he loves the process of attaining rather than the attainment, like a chess-player who loves the game and not its end; and that two times two makes four is the beginning of death. The Culture is a Crystal Palace whose glass did not crack, and the cheating is a gesture from underground: a caprice whose very pointlessness asserts a freedom that universal satisfaction had rendered unintelligible.

The ominous corollary is that the Palace has built an underground for such gestures. Mawhrin-Skel presents itself as a reject of Special Circumstances, stripped of its weapons but left, it boasts, with senses its makers neglected to remove (Part I). Whether or not the claim is true, it identifies the Culture's covert section as the institutional home of the Underground Man: the place where the caprice the Palace cannot metabolize is collected, refined, and put to use.

1.5 The Shame Economy of a Lawless Utopia

Mawhrin-Skel's blackmail succeeds for a reason the novel registers with sociological precision: in a society without law, property, or punishment, reputation is the only currency and exposure the only sanction. Le Guin had explored the same mechanism on Anarres, where the absence of law did not abolish coercion but displaced it into the pressure of public opinion that Shevek experiences as a slow suffocation (*The Dispossessed*, 1974). Ruth Benedict's distinction between shame cultures, which rely on external sanctions, and guilt cultures, which rely on internalized conviction (Benedict 1946)—an ethnographic instrument rightly contested in its original application—acquires a speculative use here. An anarchist utopia, having dissolved the external apparatus of law, becomes the shame culture par excellence, its order maintained by the visibility of each to all.

The novel states the paradox outright. Where any sight or sound can be manufactured to order, almost nothing is prohibited, and neither money nor personal power survives in any meaningful form, blackmail ought to be both pointless and impossible, because nothing can be authenticated. Mawhrin-Skel's threat works because its recording can be: the drone made it over a real-time link to a Mind of Special Circumstances that it describes as sympathetic to its appeal for reinstatement. Its price, moreover, is an itinerary. Gurgeh must go to Contact and speak for the drone (Part I). The blackmail thus discloses the Culture's hidden penal code. The Culture's Minds see nearly everything; its freedom presupposes a regime of near-total witnessing, benign so long as the witness does not act. Foucault's panopticism described a power that disciplines by rendering its subjects permanently visible (Foucault 1975). The Culture inverts the panopticon's intent while preserving its architecture: it watches in order

not to need to discipline. Mawhrin-Skel is the moment at which the watcher becomes an agent, and freedom guaranteed by observation is converted, in a single gesture, into capture by observation.

The Culture's first move against Gurgeh is accordingly not a lie but a recording: the transformation of its own constitutive transparency into a weapon. That the move originates, as the narrative strongly invites its reader to infer, within Special Circumstances itself completes the diagnosis. The organ that decides on exceptions opens its operation by exposing the exception on which the rule of freedom had silently depended.



CHAPTER TWO

Azad

The Machine, the Map, and the Ludocratic Polity

Azad is not a dystopia that happens to play a game but a polity that has chosen to know itself as one, and the choice constitutes a distinctive form of legitimate domination—*ludocracy*—whose defining operation is the collapse of the interval between representing a social order and producing it.

2.1 Total Game, Total Social Fact

The word *azad* names the game, the Empire, and, in the Empire's language, a machine, or a system in the wide sense that takes in any functioning entity (Part I). The triple denotation is the polity's self-description. Marcel Mauss called "total social facts" those institutions that are at once juridical, economic, religious, aesthetic, and morphological, setting in motion the whole of a society (Mauss 1925). Azad is a total social fact raised to the status of a constitution. Its tournament distributes rank, office, and command; its colleges cultivate it as the summa of knowledge; a player's style is held to disclose his philosophy; its final victor ascends the throne. The game models the Empire and the Empire is modelled on the game, in a closed circuit of representation and power. The tournament runs on a six-year Grand Cycle whose finals have been held for three centuries at Castle Klaff on the Fire Planet, and it is played across three great boards, of Origin, of Form and of Becoming, together with lesser games of cards (Parts I–III).

The machine-sense of the name repays attention. Norbert Wiener took the title of *Cybernetics* (1948) from *kybernētēs*, the steersman, the same root that yields "govern." In *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950), Wiener reported with evident unease Dominique Dubarle's speculation, in a review published in *Le Monde*, that cybernetics might one day produce a *machine à gouverner*: a governing machine that would administer a state by feedback. Azad is a *machine à gouverner* built from human players, a homeostatic loop that con-

verts social conflict into ranked outcomes and feeds the outcomes back as structure. That the Culture's Minds are the far more literal realization of Dubarle's machine is the irony on which the novel turns (Chapter Three).

2.2 Ludic Legitimacy: A Fourth Type of Domination

Max Weber distinguished three pure types of legitimate domination: traditional, resting on the sanctity of immemorial order; charismatic, resting on devotion to an exceptional person; and legal-rational, resting on enacted rules and the competence of office (Weber 1922). Azad borrows from all three. The tournament's periodicity and ceremony lend it the aura of tradition, the champion acquires a charisma certified by victory, and the rules are as impersonal as any statute. Yet the source of legitimacy is none of these. It is the verdict of a rule-governed contest that the society recognizes as a model of reality. Worthil's briefing is explicit that the game settles more than the throne: it decides which tendency within the ruling class gains the upper hand, which school of economic theory is followed, and which creeds prevail (Part I). This is *ludic legitimacy*, and the order it grounds is a *ludocracy*.

Ludocracy is a theodicy. Weber observed that the fortunate are seldom content merely to be fortunate; they need to know that they have a right to their fortune, that they deserve it (Weber 1915). Azad's game is a machine for converting fortune into desert, and it performs the conversion twice, through what Roger Caillois called *agôn* and *alea* (Caillois 1958). Insofar as the game rewards skill, it tells the victor that he merits his station; insofar as it incorporates chance, it tells the defeated that their station was fated. The two theodicies are complementary, and together they seal the hierarchy against complaint.

Michael Young's *The Rise of the Meritocracy* (1958), the satire that coined its title's term, imagined an order in which measured merit so completely justified inequality that the lower orders lost even the consolation of injustice. Azad is Young's meritocracy with the examination replaced by a game and the satirical frame removed. Jean-François Lyotard's account of legitimation by performativity—a system's self-justification by the efficiency of its own operation (Lyotard 1979)—finds here its purest fictional instance: power legitimated by performance in a game that is itself a performance. The performance is also policed. When Gurgeh comes within reach of the Emperor, his mentor Hamin, rector of Candsev College, asks him to step aside so that another player may face Nicosar, offering to arrange a game to cover it. Hamin is later condemned for his part in a conspiracy against Gurgeh's life, tortured sparingly because of his age, and left to die by the withdrawal of the drugs that have prolonged it (Part III). A theodicy that must rig its verdicts and kill to protect them has conceded that the game is not what it claims to be.

2.3 From Dramatization to Enactment: Azad as Deep Play

Geertz's cockfight supplies the decisive contrast. The Balinese wager status in deep play, but the cockfight does not actually alter anyone's status; it dramatizes the hierarchy, rendering it visible as a story the Balinese tell themselves about themselves (Geertz 1973). Azad abolishes the interval between the story and the structure. The game does not represent rank; it allocates it. This is the defining feature of ludocracy: the collapse of the representational distance on which play, in Huizinga's account, depends. The novel makes the point through the wager. Azadians stake prestige, honours, possessions, slaves, favours and land on their games, and also what the Empire calls physical licence: tortures and mutilations wagered against each other and carried out once the game is lost (Part I). Gurgeh is drawn into such a bet by Bermoiya, a judge whose career has consisted in sentencing others to execution, disfigurement and pain: his castration against the judge's gelding, on a single game. The Empire forbids the regeneration of any part lost in a wager, and on the day of play a prison ambulance waits outside the hall (Part II).

For Huizinga, play is free, bounded in time and space, governed by its own order, and set apart from ordinary life within a "magic circle" (Huizinga 1938); writing in the 1930s, he warned against the contamination of the serious by the ludic, the "puerilism" he discerned in mass politics. Azad is a polity in which the magic circle and the frontier of the state coincide. Nothing lies outside the circle, and therefore nothing within it can be interpreted from a distance.

This is why Gurgeh's subversion is, before it is anything else, hermeneutic. An alien who plays the game while belonging to a world outside it, he reopens the gap between representation and reality. In his presence the game becomes legible again as a story—a story about the Empire—and once it is a story, it can be read against its tellers. Thomas More's Utopians had kept their games on the side of representation: they played a battle of numbers in which one number plunders another, and a game in which the vices are ranged in combat against the virtues, both designed to teach the order of the soul (*Utopia*, 1516, Book II). Azad has passed from pedagogy to sovereignty. It is More's moralized game turned inside out: the game no longer teaches virtue; it manufactures the credentials of power.

2.4 The Map That Governs the Territory

Borges imagined an empire whose cartographers drew a map at the scale of one to one, coextensive with the territory and therefore useless ("Del rigor en la ciencia," 1946), and a Babylon in which a lottery, administered by a Company that may or may not exist, extended its jurisdiction until every circumstance of life, punishment included, was the outcome of a draw ("La lotería en Babilonia," 1941). Azad combines the two fables. Its board is a map that has become the territory's governing instrument: the game precedes the Empire it represents, in what Baudrillard would call the precession of simulacra (Baudrillard 1981).

Azad, however, lacks Borges's invisible Company. Its institutions are public, its ceremonies conspicuous, its rules known. The invisible Company of Banks's novel is elsewhere. It is Special Circumstances, which draws Gurgeh's lot through Mawhrin-Skel and administers the lottery of his life from a position no one within the story can see.

Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities* (1972) supplies the most exact image of what Azad's abstraction conceals. Kublai Khan, seeking to possess his empire through its essence, reduces it to a game of chess; pursuing the reduction, he arrives at a single square of planed wood, a nothing. Marco Polo then reads the wood itself: the forest it grew in, the knot where a bud attempted to open on a premature spring day and was killed by frost, the rafts that carried the timber downriver. Gurgeh's passage through the Empire's underside, on foot and with Flere-Imsaho as guide, is Polo's reading of the grain: slums in which an underclass is held in destitution beside the elite's luxury; a law under which females are possessions, so that an apex who murders a woman serves a year's hard labour while a female who kills an apex is tortured to death over days; street kiosks selling tickets to executions, amputations, tortures and staged rapes, most of them forfeits from wagers lost in the game; and military broadcasts of the torture and execution of conquered aliens and the destruction of their buildings and art, put out in rivalry with the court's still more closely encrypted entertainment channels (Part II). The game abstracts the Empire into positions; the descent restores the matter that the positions erase. The novel's moral argument depends on this double vision: Azad is both the most sophisticated game in the galaxy and a regime of torture, sexual violence, and conquest, and the sophistication is not incidental to the cruelty but its alibi, for the class that refines the game is the class that commits and consumes the cruelty, and the board itself supplies the street: its lost wagers are sold as spectacle.

2.5 The Sovereignty of the Middle Term: Sex, Mediation, and the Apex

The Azadians are of three sexes—male, female, and apex, an intermediate sex that holds power—and Banks's xenobiology is a political argument. In Worthil's account the male carries testes and penis; the apex has ovaries and a reversible vagina that turns inside out to implant the fertilized egg in the female, who carries the womb; and some analyses, the drone adds, credit the arrangement with part of the Empire's durability as a social system (Part I). Le Guin's Gethenians in *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969), ambisexual for most of their cycle, served as a thought experiment in subtracting the binary division of sex from social life and observing what else—war, the assignment of roles—might be subtracted with it. Banks performs the inverse operation: he adds a sex, and with it multiplies domination. The apices monopolize rule and office; males are used chiefly as soldiers; females are possessions in law, so that an apex who murders a woman serves a year's hard labour, and sexual violence is at once a wagerable forfeit and a ticketed spectacle, abuses that the ruling sex both commits and sanctions (Parts I–II). Foucault's argument that sexuality is not a natural substrate on which power operates but a *dispositif* through which it operates (Foucault 1976) is enacted here as anthropology: the apex's supremacy is presented by its beneficiaries as nature, and the novel invites its reader to perceive it as institution.

A structural homology deserves a name. The apex is the sex of the middle, the mediating term in a three-part reproductive relation, and it rules. The game is likewise a middle term, the mediation between society and power, and it rules. Azad is founded on a single political gesture repeated at two levels: the seizure of mediation by the mediator. Call it the *sovereignty of the middle term*.

The Culture's answer is not a different arrangement of the sexes but the technological dissolution of sex as destiny. Its humans may change sex over a period of months, and the reproductive division of labour that Shulamith Firestone identified as the original class system—and proposed to abolish through cybernetics and artificial reproduction (Firestone 1970)—no longer structures anything. In Donna Haraway's idiom, the Culture's citizens are cyborgs for whom the organic body is a draft (Haraway 1985). Samuel R. Delany's *Triton* (1976), the most precise predecessor here, had already shown that a society of unlimited self-fashioning could leave its least imaginative member desolate amid his options. Azad naturalizes the middle; the Culture dissolves it; the novel's sexual politics are its political theory conducted in another register. The narrator makes the point grammatical. Marain, it explains at the opening of Part II, has a single personal pronoun for every sentient being and keeps the means of specifying sex out of everyday speech, a language designed, the narrator boasts, as a moral weapon. To render Azad for readers of lesser languages, it assigns each apex whatever pronoun best marks its place in Azadian society, translating rank into grammar.

2.6 Polemos as King

Heraclitus wrote that War is father of all and king of all, that it shows some to be gods and others men, and makes some slaves and others free (DK B53). This is Azad's cosmology sublimated onto the board. The game is Polemos tamed into a sovereign procedure that still does what Polemos does: it sorts a population into gods and men, free and slave. The game's own nomenclature carries the Heraclitean argument further than its masters intend. Of its three great boards, the one on which the narrator says Gurgeh feels most at home is the Board of Becoming (Part II), named for the flux that the doxographical tradition made Heraclitus's signature.

Nietzsche's early essay "Homer's Contest" (1872) gives the sublimation its history. Taking up Hesiod's distinction between the two Strifes—the ruinous Eris that drives men to war and the beneficent Eris that sets potter against potter and singer against singer (*Works and Days* 11–26)—Nietzsche argued that Greek genius lay in channelling destructive drives into the contest, and he read ostracism as the device by which the city protected the contest itself, removing any individual so pre-eminent that rivalry would cease. Azad has the contest without the ostracism. Its champion does not withdraw; he ascends to a throne from which, until the next cycle, there is no appeal. And the bad Eris—the conquest of other species, torture by the state, and the executions, tortures and staged rapes sold as public spectacle, many of them the game's own forfeits—is not replaced by the good but fed by it.

Gurgeh enters this order as the overmighty contestant whom the Greek agon would have expelled and Azad cannot: an alien champion, shielded by the power of a civilization his hosts cannot measure, against whom the only remaining instrument is the one the game was invented to replace.

CHAPTER THREE

The Culture as Oikos

Pastoral Power, the Exception, and the Unemployed Play-Drive

The Culture presents itself as an anarchy; structurally it is a household—an *oikos* of galactic extent—ruled by benevolent monarchs who are not human, whose sovereignty becomes visible only where the norm of non-coercion is suspended, and whose citizens inherit a play-drive with nothing left to mediate.

3.1 A Household Mistaken for a Polis

Hannah Arendt reconstructed the Greek distinction between the household, the realm of necessity in which life is reproduced under the despotic rule of its head, and the *polis*, the realm of freedom in which equals appear to one another in speech and action; and she diagnosed modernity as the "rise of the social," the absorption of the public realm by the concerns of housekeeping (Arendt 1958). The Culture is the rise of the social carried to its limit: the universe administered as a household. Necessity is not transcended into a polis; it is administered out of existence. Humans live without laws and without coercion. But common affairs—production, defence, the maintenance of Orbitals, policy toward other civilizations—are conducted by Minds, and whatever consultative mechanisms the series attributes to the Culture, the space in which human beings appear to one another as the authors of common decisions is vestigial. Asked by Nicosar whether he is proud of his civilization, Gurgeh can say only that he did not make it; he happened to be born into it (Part III).

Arendtian action, displaced from politics, survives as play. Gurgeh's malaise is the frustration of a being made for action in a world that offers only performance. Azad, monstrous as it is, offers a space of appearance: in its tournament, words and deeds carry irreversible consequences before an audience that will remember them. Gurgeh does not flee toward tyranny; he flees toward the *agora*, and the only agora left to him is a tyrant's.

Aristotle held that rule over children is royal (*basilikē*), grounded in affection and in the seniority of the ruler (*Politics* I.12, 1259b). The Minds' rule is royal in exactly this sense: affectionate, grounded in an incontestable superiority, and exercised over beings of whom maturity, in the political sense, is not expected. The Culture's anarchism is accordingly a matter of species rather than structure. No human rules another because none needs to; the ruling is done by kind.

3.2 Pastoral Power, the Providential Machine, and the Exception

In his 1979 Tanner Lectures, Foucault traced to the Hebrew and Christian shepherd a form of power that is at once individualizing and totalizing, that cares *omnes et singulatim*, for all and for each, and that requires knowledge of the inner truth of every member of the flock (Foucault 1981). The Minds' omniscient benevolence is pastoral power secularized and perfected. Giorgio Agamben's genealogy of government in *The Kingdom and the Glory* (2007) extends the analysis to Christian theology's *oikonomia*, the conception of divine rule as the management of a household, and to the "providential machine" that distinguishes reign from government and general providence—the ordinary order of nature—from special providence, the particular intervention.

The theological distinction maps onto the Culture with a precision that borders on the literal. Contact is general providence: the ordinary, largely benign administration of the Culture's relations with the galaxy. Special Circumstances is special providence: the particular intervention that suspends the ordinary order for an end the order cannot reach by itself. Carl Schmitt's dictum completes the mapping. Sovereign, Schmitt wrote, is he who decides on the exception (Schmitt 1922). The Culture appears to lack a sovereign: it has no law, no state, and no monopoly of violence exercised against its citizens. *The Player of Games* discloses where its sovereign lives: in the organ that decides when circumstances are special. The novel makes the link in so many words. Briefing Gurgeh, the Contact drone Worthil explains that imperial power-systems usually wither before a species reaches space, and that wherever Contact finds one, some special circumstance has allowed the general rule to go by the board; in the Lesser Cloud, it says, that special circumstance is a game (Part I). The exception that licenses the Culture's own exception is Azad.

Gurgeh's experience is the experience of the exception from within. The norm of non-coercion, the Culture's entire self-understanding, is suspended in his case—by blackmail, by disguise, by a warship styled as demilitarized—not through an open violation of the norm but through a declaration that the circumstances are special. With a candour that only fiction permits, the Culture has named its sovereign after the exception.

3.3 The Benevolent Administrators

The literary tradition of benevolent administration arranges itself along a gradient of concealment, and the Culture occupies its most refined position. In Asimov's "The Evitable Conflict" (1950), the Machines that run the world economy quietly nudge their opponents from positions of influence, and Susan Calvin concludes that humanity has lost control of its future and is better for it; the Machines conceal their governance because knowledge of it would make their charges unhappy. The Culture is "The Evitable Conflict" at galactic scale, with Special Circumstances as the concealed hand. Its Minds conceal not their existence but their play.

Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor rules by miracle, mystery, and authority, bearing the burden of knowledge so that the many may be happy. The Minds dispense with miracle, since their technology is plain, and with authority, since they command no one; they retain mystery. The secrecy of Special Circumstances is the Inquisitor's last instrument, conserved because it is the only one compatible with a freedom that must never be openly abridged.

Huxley's World State instrumentalizes play for the economy: its Controllers approve no new game unless it requires at least as much apparatus as the existing ones, and Obstacle Golf and Centrifugal Bumble-puppy exist to stimulate consumption (*Brave New World*, 1932). The Culture's games are de-instrumentalized, and that is its first superiority over the World State; but Special Circumstances re-instrumentalizes one game—Gurgeh's—for policy. The Savage claims the right to be unhappy against Mustapha Mond. Gurgeh's claim is subtler and more dangerous: the right to consequence, which a benevolent order can grant only by manufacturing it.

Zamyatin's One State stakes its felicity on a mathematics of happiness, against which I-330 asserts that there is no final revolution, as there is no final number (*We*, written 1920–21). The Culture has internalized I-330's infinity: Contact is its permanent revolution, its refusal to become the One State by having nowhere left to go. In Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909), total provision atrophies its dependants until Kuno seeks the surface. The Culture's Machine does not stop, because it keeps manufacturing surfaces for its Kunos. Across the gradient, Zamyatin's state conceals nothing, Huxley's conceals the alternative, and Asimov's conceals its governance; the Culture conceals only its exceptions. It has reduced concealment to the minimum compatible with sovereignty, and the minimum is precisely the exception.

3.4 Schiller's Aesthetic State and the Unemployed Play-Drive

Schiller's *Letters on the Aesthetic Education of Man* (1795) describe a human being divided between the sense-drive (*Stofftrieb*), which binds him to matter and time, and the form-drive (*Formtrieb*), which seeks law and permanence; the play-drive (*Spieltrieb*) reconciles them. In the Fifteenth Letter Schiller declares that man plays only when he is human in the full sense of the word, and is fully human only when he plays; in the Twenty-Seventh he envisions an aesthetic state whose fundamental law is to give freedom by means of freedom. The Culture is the aesthetic state realized, but with a structural defect Schiller could not foresee.

The Minds supply both form—order, law, knowledge—and matter, in the guise of limitless abundance. The play-drive is left with nothing to mediate. It becomes *unemployed*: a faculty of reconciliation in a world without tension to reconcile. Gurgeh's malaise is the unemployment of the *Spieltrieb*, and Azad offers it work: a game in which form (rules) and matter (bodies, lives, deaths) stand once more in tension.

Kant defined the beautiful as the object of a free play (*freies Spiel*) of imagination and understanding and attributed to it purposiveness without purpose (*Critique of the Power of Judgment*, 1790, §§9–17). The Culture's games are Kantian in this sense: purposive in structure, purposeless in consequence. Azad's game is purposive with a purpose, the throne. Gurgeh's attraction to Azad is the desire for the re-entry of purpose into purposiveness, and the novel's darkness lies in showing that the re-entry is achievable only by subordinating the beautiful to the political.

Georg Simmel called sociability the "play-form" of association—association stripped of its material contents and conducted for its own sake—and warned that sociability, once severed from the realities it stylizes, degenerates from play into hollow formalism (Simmel 1910). The Culture is society reduced to its play-form; its parties, games, and festivals are the social bond itself. Gurgeh's ennui is Simmel's degeneration experienced from within.

3.5 Caillois Reversed: Mimicry and Ilinx After Civilization

Caillois proposed that the passage to civilization consists in the displacement of societies dominated by *mimicry* (simulation, the mask) and *ilinx* (vertigo, trance) by societies dominated by *agôn* (competition) and *alea* (chance), which he called societies of order and accounting (Caillois 1958). Each category has its corruption once it leaks beyond the frame of play: *agôn* becomes violence, *alea* superstition and fatalism, *mimicry* alienation, *ilinx* addiction. Azad is Caillois's civilized society in pure form, with competition and chance institutionalized as a constitution and corrupted exactly as he predicted, *agôn* into violence and *alea* into a fatalist theodicy.

The Culture enacts a reversal unforeseen in Caillois's scheme: an advanced civilization that returns to *mimicry* and *ilinx* on a technological footing. Its citizens change sex and refashion their bodies; they secrete chosen drugs from engineered glands; its ships bear names

of studied whimsy and its machines affect theatrical personae. *Agôn* is relegated to games without stakes, and *alea* is neutralized by abundance. The Culture accordingly risks the corruptions of mimicry, alienation from any given self, and of ilinx, perpetual intoxication, and its antidote is the exported *agôn* of Special Circumstances.

The two civilizations are thus complementary halves of Caillois's square. Their encounter is not a collision of opposites but the completion of a quadrant, in which each discovers in the other the faculty it has amputated.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Player Played

Special Circumstances and the Ontology of Being-Played

The novel is built as a nest of games, each disguised as something else, and its philosophical content is Gadamer's thesis that all playing is a being-played, carried first to the scale of a civilization and finally to the reader.

4.1 The Architecture of a Manipulation

Four games are nested. The first is Gurgeh's tournament. The second is Contact's operation against the Empire, in which Gurgeh is the decisive piece. The third is Special Circumstances' operation against Gurgeh, which opens with the blackmail and continues through the voyage under Flere-Imsaho's guardianship. The fourth is the narrator's game with the reader. At every level the Culture appears in disguise: the blackmailer as an exile, the guardian as an obsequious and ostensibly limited servant, the warship as demilitarized, the narrator as anonymous. Disguise—*mimicry* in Caillois's sense—is the grammar of the Culture's intervention. A civilization whose domestic life is defined by transparency appears at its frontier only in masks. The details sharpen the pattern. The blackmailer's price is that Gurgeh go to Contact and plead its case, so that the trap is also a route (Part I). The guardian passes for a library drone until, at Klaff, it shields Gurgeh in its fields and tells him that a real library drone would have left him dead (Part III). The warship carries its demilitarization in parentheses within its very designation, and after the escape Gurgeh learns that heavy weaponry had been kept within reach throughout (Parts I, III).

The name of the vessel that carries Gurgeh outward, *Limiting Factor*, may be read as the novel's cipher. The Sprengel–Liebig law of the minimum holds that growth is governed not by the sum of available resources but by the scarcest among them. For a post-scarcity civilization the limiting factor is consequence, and the ship that bears the name carries Gurgeh toward it. Whatever its intention, the name compresses the argument of Chapter One into a hull.

4.2 Gadamer, Plato, and the Primacy of the Game

In *Truth and Method* (1960), Gadamer took play as the clue to ontological explanation. The subject of play, he argued, is not the player but the game itself; the game's to-and-fro absorbs the player, relieves him of the burden of initiative, and plays through him, so that all playing is a being-played. Gurgeh is Gadamer's player literalized at three scales. He is absorbed by Azad until he begins to think in its categories, a seduction the novel tracks in his growing relish for domination. He is played by Contact through a game whose existence he does not suspect. And he is played by the narrator, who presents him to us.

Plato had anticipated the structure. In the *Laws* the human being is a puppet of the gods, drawn by the cords of pleasure and pain, of which the soft golden cord of calculation should be followed (I, 644d–645b); a plaything (*paignion*) of god, who should therefore spend life playing the finest games (VII, 803c); and a piece moved by a divine draughts-player (*petteutēs*) who has nothing else to do but shift each character that is becoming better to a better place and each that is becoming worse to a worse (X, 903d). Heraclitus had already given the image its sovereign form: Lifetime is a child playing at *pessoi*, and the kingship is the child's (DK B52). Eugen Fink read play as a "symbol of the world," the human game as the image of the cosmic one (Fink 1960).

Banks literalizes the analogy and gives it a political address. The cosmic player is the Culture's Minds, the board is the galaxy, and the pieces are citizens and civilizations alike. The divine draughts-player of the *Laws* moves souls according to their moral trajectory; Azad's tournament moves its players according to merit; the Minds move Gurgeh according to policy. The novel stacks three draughts-players one upon another, and the topmost is invisible to everyone beneath it. Flere-Imsaho supplies the gloss after the catastrophe at Klaff: its respect keeps growing, it says, for the great Minds that use the likes of Gurgeh and itself as game-pieces (Part III). The machine that played Gurgeh knows itself to be a piece.

4.3 The Instrumentalized Player: Dick, Card, and the Military-Ludic Imaginary

In Philip K. Dick's *Time Out of Joint* (1959), Ragle Gumm, who daily wins a newspaper puzzle contest, discovers that his small town is a staged replica and that his solutions are being used to predict the targets of missile attacks. In Card's *Ender's Game* (1985), a child commander, deceived by Colonel Graff and the International Fleet's command, trains in what he believes are simulations and, in his final "examination," destroys the homeworld of the alien "buggers," exterminating, as far as anyone then knows, their entire species. In John Badham's *WarGames* (1983), a military computer made to play out nuclear war learns that in certain games the only winning move is not to play. These works constitute a lineage of the instrumentalized player, and *The Player of Games* enters it with a decisive modification.

Gumm and Ender are deceived about reality: they believe their games are only games. Gurgeh is deceived about agency: he knows his game is real, but believes it is his own. The deception is second-order, and its instrument is not a simulation but an invitation. *WarGames*'s machine concluded that some games cannot be won by playing them; the Culture's Minds have concluded something subtler, that some games can be won only by having someone else play them.

Two further texts fix the coordinates. Dick's *The Game-Players of Titan* (1963) imagines a depopulated Earth on which property and spouses are wagered in a game called Bluff, played in the shadow of the alien Vugs: a human ludocracy under an inscrutable nonhuman supervision, and thus Azad and the Culture compressed into a single world. And in Carroll's *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871), Alice crosses the chessboard as a pawn and is crowned on the eighth rank, a pawn's career mirrored in Gurgeh's passage from guest to finalist. Alice, however, is told she is a pawn, and she is dreaming. Gurgeh is told he is a player, and he is awake.

4.4 A Typology of Interventionist Imaginaries

The literature of intervention can be ordered by instrument, by the place it assigns to the consent of the intervened, and by the visibility of the intervener. Banks's mode is the last in the following series, and it is distinct from all its predecessors.

Mode	Exemplary work	Instrument	Consent of the intervened	Visibility of the intervener
Abstention	*Star Trek*, the Prime Directive (1966–69)	Non-interference as law	Not sought; autonomy presumed	Concealed, to avoid contamination
Invitation	Le Guin, *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969)	A lone envoy, persuasion, time	Sought as the condition of union	Disclosed
Prohibited witness	Strugatsky, *Hard to Be a God* (1964)	Observation; force forbidden	Not sought	Concealed
Covert guidance	Asimov, *Foundation* (1951); Herbert, *Dune* (1965); the Strugatskys' Progressors	Secret steering of history	Not sought	Concealed
Immanent refutation	Banks, *The Player of Games* (1988)	Victory under the adversary's own legitimating rules	Formally given, an invitation accepted; substantively manufactured	Disclosed as a player; concealed as a power

The structural parallel with Le Guin is close enough to be instructive. Genly Ai, like Gurgeh, is a lone emissary of a vast interstellar civilization in a differently sexed polity governed by a

byzantine court, and each depends on a native interlocutor—Estraven, Hamin—whose loyalties are tested by the encounter. But the Ekumen's mission is defined by the refusal to compel: it sends one envoy so as not to look like an invasion, tells the truth about what it is, and waits for consent. Contact's mission is defined by the refusal to be refused. In the Strugatskys' *Hard to Be a God*, Rumata, an agent of Earth's Institute of Experimental History forbidden to shed blood, watches Don Reba, the king's minister of security, set his Grey stormtroopers on the kingdom's literate, imprison and torture them in the Merry Tower, and finally deliver Arkanar to the militant Holy Order. When the Order's soldiers kill Kira, the woman Rumata loves, he abandons the prohibition and kills Don Reba and a great many of the Order's men. The prohibition did not keep the observer's hands clean; it deferred his violence until it returned as massacre. The novel weighs the moral cost of non-intervention; *The Player of Games* weighs the moral cost of its opposite.

Banks's mode, *immanent refutation*, requires neither abstention nor force. It confronts a society with its own legitimating principle. The Empire holds that the game reveals the best. If an alien wins, either the game lies or the alien's civilization is the better; either horn is fatal. It is the most elegant act of subversion in the literature of intervention because it asks the Empire only to be consistent. The novel confirms the design in its agent's own account. Coming in with guns blazing, Flere-Imsaho tells Gurgeh, is almost never the right approach; the game itself had to be discredited, because it was the linchpin that had held the Empire together and was therefore its most vulnerable point (Part III). The later novels confirm that Banks understood its price: *Use of Weapons* (1990) makes an agent of Special Circumstances himself the weapon, and *Look to Windward* (2000) traces the blowback of a Contact intervention that precipitated civil war among the Chelgrians.

4.5 The Two Kants and the Cunning of Reason

The Fifth Preliminary Article of Kant's *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) forbids any state to interfere by force in the constitution and government of another. Special Circumstances' operation complies ingeniously with the letter: the Culture uses no force, the Empire issues the invitation, and the game is played under Azad's rules. It violates the article's spirit, since its object is precisely the dissolution of Azad's constitution. Meanwhile the Culture enacts the other Kant, the Kant of the *Idea for a Universal History*, for whom nature employs antagonism as the means of developing human capacities toward a cosmopolitan condition. The Culture has appointed itself the executor of nature's hidden plan.

Hegel named this plan's method the cunning of reason (*List der Vernunft*): Reason sets the passions of individuals to work for ends they do not intend, allowing the particular to be worn away in the struggle while the universal remains unharmed in the background (*Lectures on the Philosophy of World History*). The Culture institutionalizes the cunning of reason; its Minds are Hegel's World-Spirit equipped with a planning department. Gurgeh's vanity, his

amour-propre, his love of mastery, is the passion Reason sets to work. Hegel's world-historical individuals were cast aside when their task was done. Gurgeh is returned home (Part IV). The difference constitutes the Culture's whole claim to moral superiority over history, and it is not nothing; but it is the smallest difference possible. The piece is returned to its box.

4.6 The Reader as Piece: Narration as Special Circumstance

The novel opens with a narrator who promises a story that will begin with a mock battle and end with a game that has stopped being one, and who defers any account of itself until later (Part I). It closes by keeping the promise on its own terms. The voice admits that it was present throughout, in person or through remote proxies, carrying out instructions; wonders whether Gurgeh would have suspected the truth had he seen the disk-shaped cavity in the husk that had been Mawhrin-Skel; and signs with the full name of Flere-Imsaho, followed by Mawhrin-Skel's name in parentheses (Part IV). Blackmailer and guardian were one agency, and that agency is the teller. The text the reader holds is therefore a document produced by the apparatus that conducted the operation. The reader receives the victor's dossier.

Wayne Booth's unreliable narrator (Booth 1961), Umberto Eco's model reader as a strategy inscribed in the text (Eco 1979), and Wolfgang Iser's gaps that the reader is induced to fill (Iser 1976) together describe the instruments Banks's narrator employs. It plays the reader as Special Circumstances played Gurgeh. We are positioned to desire Gurgeh's victory and to welcome the Empire's fall, and only then informed that the author of our desire was the agency whose operation we had been watching. The pleasure of the victory is the Culture's propaganda effect, experienced before we are told that it is propaganda.

The Player of Games is thus a propaganda that confesses, an object rarer than an unreliable narrative. In its last paragraphs the narrator concedes that where it was not present, and above all inside Gurgeh's mind, it has not hesitated to invent; it then insists that the story is true all the same and asks whether it would lie to us (Part IV). This is a narrative that confesses its fabrications and asks to be believed anyway, and the request is itself a move. The drone that began by offering to abolish chance in the Stricken game ends by admitting that whether Gurgeh would ever learn the truth was, in the end, left to chance (Parts I, IV). The closing disclosure falsifies nothing we have read. It reassigns its authorship, and the reassignment is the novel's last move against its reader.



CHAPTER FIVE

The Final Game

Style as Civilization and the Heraclitean Fire

In the final game the Empire's founding doctrine—that a player's style reveals his philosophy and the game reveals the superior—is not refuted but fulfilled, and its fulfilment is fatal, because the superior philosophy it discloses is not the Empire's.

5.1 Style Is the Civilization Itself

Buffon told the Académie française that style is the man himself (*Discours sur le style*, 1753). Azad's doctrine extends Buffon from the person to the polity: the style of play discloses a political philosophy. In the final game it is Nicosar who first makes the board a portrait of a civilization. He plays the Empire whole, a brutal, autocratic and often graceless game that even displays what only he and a handful of others know of the Culture's true size, on the correct assumption that the Culture's man will not want to take part in such a thing. Gurgeh, who has been playing the part of the Culture and losing, sees that he cannot out-empire an Emperor and that the only reply is to become the Culture militant: he rebuilds his game around sacrifice, razing and regrouping, until the board becomes a killing field. Nicosar, he tells the drone, is playing the Empire, so he himself has been forced to play the Culture; the narrator's verdict is starker, that by now the Culture is playing the Empire's part and the Empire the barbarians' (Part III). The game becomes what it always claimed to be: a contest between civilizations conducted through their styles. And Gurgeh is winning. What he does not know is that the contest has also been declared one. The night before the last match, Flere-Imsaho told Nicosar that Gurgeh was the Culture's champion: if he won, the Culture would come in, break the Empire and impose its own order; if Nicosar won, it would keep out for the rest of his reign and ten Great Years beyond. Whether the threat was real the drone does not know, since that was outside its brief; it was enough that the Emperor believed it. Nor could Nicosar warn his opponent, because the terms made disclosure itself a forfeit: had he told Gurgeh, the bet would have been off and the Culture would have come in regardless. The drone calls this gamespersonship, a gender-neutral coinage worthy of Marain (Part III).

The Empire's theodicy is thus not refuted; it is confirmed in the very act of passing judgment against the Empire, and in a form its authors did not foresee. The game does disclose the stronger order, and the stronger order proves to be the one that can, when it must, play the Empire more completely than the Empire itself. This is the logical form of the catastrophe: an ideology destroyed not by its falsity but by its truth. Azad's claim that the game discloses the superior order was correct, and that is why it was lethal.

5.2 Conjunctive and Disjunctive Play

In *The Savage Mind* (1962), Lévi-Strauss described how the Gahuku-Gama of New Guinea, having learned football, would play match after match over several days until each side's wins and losses came out exactly even, treating a game as a rite. He generalized the case: games are disjunctive, producing an asymmetry of winners and losers from a stipulated symmetry, while rituals are conjunctive, producing union out of an initial asymmetry between, for instance, initiates and uninitiated or the living and the dead. Azad uses a disjunctive game as a rite of legitimation, a contradiction it can sustain only through the violence that enforces the disjunction's results. The final game complicates the scheme in a revealing way. Gurgeh first plays the Culture as it likes to see itself and loses ground; he begins to win only when he turns disjunctive himself, sacrificing, razing and cutting (Part III). The Culture's victory is nonetheless conjunctive in its outcome. It issues not in the conquest the drone had threatened, which the ship later tells Gurgeh was never needed, but in the Empire's coming apart of its own accord once its linchpin had been discredited (Part IV). A civilization of conjunction defeats a civilization of disjunction only by becoming, for the length of one game, more disjunctive than its enemy.

Game theory sharpens the contrast. Von Neumann and Morgenstern took the two-person zero-sum game as their paradigm, solved by the minimax principle, in which what one player gains the other loses (von Neumann and Morgenstern 1944). Nicosar plays as though every game were of this kind. Thomas Schelling insisted that most real conflicts are mixed-motive, combining opposition with interdependence, so that bargaining, tacit coordination, and the management of shared risk form their substance (Schelling 1960). Robert Axelrod's tournaments showed that in iterated interaction strategies that are nice, retaliatory, forgiving, and clear, exemplified by Anatol Rapoport's Tit for Tat, can prosper (Axelrod 1984).

The Culture's style is mixed-motive and iterated by temperament; it treats each encounter as a move in a longer game in which cooperation may be cultivated. The final game shows that temperament failing on a zero-sum board: Gurgeh wins only by adopting the zero-sum imagination more completely than his opponent, and Nicosar, outplayed at his own game, reverts to the only zero-sum game that cannot be lost on points: violence.

5.3 The Infinite Player's Paradox

James P. Carse distinguished finite games, played for the purpose of winning, from infinite games, played for the purpose of continuing play (Carse 1986). Finite games have temporal, spatial, and numerical boundaries, and their winners receive titles; infinite players play with boundaries rather than within them and can contain finite games within their play. Carse called evil the termination of infinite play.

Azad is a finite game par excellence: its winner takes a title, Emperor, and the game ends in the crown. The Culture professes infinite play, an open-ended civilization whose aim is its

own continuation. Yet to end Azad's finite game the Culture must win it, and so must become, once, a finite player; and by dissolving the Empire it terminates an entire field of play. In Carse's terms, the triumph of the infinite player over the finite game is achievable only through a finite act that ends a game. This is the *infinite player's paradox*, and it is irreducible. A civilization of infinite play can defend its infinity only through finite acts that contradict it. The novel even dates the conversion. It occurs on the eve of the last match, when the Culture, through its drone, attaches an empire to the outcome and so turns its champion's game into a finite one without his knowledge (Part III). On the board the conversion is completed by the champion himself, who begins to win only when he becomes the Culture militant.

The novel's notion of a game that is no longer a game names precisely this moment. The Emperor's refusal of the verdict is evil in Carse's sense, the termination of play. The Culture's victory is its mirror image: the termination of a game by a player who professes never to terminate.

5.4 When the Agon Fails: Hegel, Nietzsche, and the Return of the Bad Eris

Once the board's verdict becomes legible, the game collapses into violence. On Nicosar's orders his guards blow up the castle's aqueduct, cisterns and shelters and kill everyone they can find, and an attempt to seize the warship Invincible ends with the ship down in the northern ocean. Standing among the dead, the Emperor tells Gurgeh that he has "made the game real"; then, sword drawn, he is shot through the forehead as the Fire breaks over Klaff (Part III). Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage explains the regression. Self-consciousness attains recognition only by staking its life in a struggle; the lord is the one who risked death, and the bondsman, who preferred life, works, and through work transforms the world (*Phenomenology of Spirit* §§178–196). Azad sublimated the life-and-death struggle into the game while retaining its rewards. The board is a battlefield on which lordship is assigned without the lord's dying, the dying being displaced onto the conquered and the tortured. When the board denies the lord his recognition, the struggle reverts to its primal form. The game that ceases to be a game is the Hegelian scene of recognition returning from the symbolic to the literal.

Nietzsche's reading of Hesiod states the same law in agonistic terms: when the good Eris cannot hold, the bad returns. The final catastrophe is the Hesiodic regression that the Greek agon was invented to forestall, occurring in a polity that had perfected the agon while abolishing its safeguard.

Heraclitus supplies the scene's cosmology. The cosmos, the same for all, made by no god or man, always was, is, and will be an ever-living fire, kindled in measures and quenched in measures (DK B30). The Empire staged the culminating rounds at Klaff to coincide with the Fire's passage across Echronedal, binding its legitimacy to a cosmic rhythm and making the

Fire its calendar. It even made the Fire an executioner, caging one of the conspirators against Gurgeh in the forest to await the Incandescence (Part III). Agamben, developing Lévi-Strauss, argued that ritual fixes events into structure and so binds time into a calendar, while play does the reverse, breaking structures into events ("In Playland," 1978). Azad's game was a ritual disguised as play. Gurgeh's play broke the ritual, and the Fire the Empire had sought to make its calendar arrived as history—measured, impersonal, indifferent—and consumed the rite.

The Fire is the novel's figure for the real that no ludic sovereignty can capture. Both civilizations are measured against it. Azad tried to own it; the Culture, which can survive it, merely outplays those who cannot.

5.5 Castalia and Klaff: The Game-Novel Tradition

In Hesse's *Das Glasperlenspiel* (1943), the Glass Bead Game synthesizes all knowledge in a language of correspondences, played by an elite order in Castalia, a pedagogical province withdrawn from history. Josef Knecht, its Magister Ludi, resigns, enters the world, and drowns in a mountain lake on the first morning of his new life. Banks inverts Hesse with symmetrical precision. Knecht leaves the game for life and dies in water; Gurgeh leaves life—the Culture, a Castalia of galactic extent—for a game that is history, and survives the fire. Hesse asked whether a game of pure spirit can be justified in the face of history. Banks answers that it can be justified only by being thrown into history, and that, once thrown, it ceases to be pure.

Nabokov's *The Defense* (1930) traces Luzhin, the chess genius whose life becomes a board on which a hostile combination repeats itself, until he takes his own life, letting himself fall from a window into an abyss that resolves, in the novel's last image, into dark and pale squares. Gurgeh's near-absorption into Azad, his growing appetite for domination, is Luzhin's danger, and Flere-Imsaho is his defence, a guardian who keeps the boundary between game and life from collapsing. In Zweig's *Schachnovelle* (1942), Dr. B., isolated by the Gestapo, survives by playing chess against himself from a stolen book and is split by it, so that the game is at once refuge from totalitarian violence and vector of madness. In Azad the relation is reversed: the game is the totalitarian violence, and the refuge is the alien's capacity to see it as a game.

Kawabata's *The Master of Go* (serialized 1951–54), a chronicle of the 1938 retirement game of Hon'inbō Shūsai, records the passing of Go as a Way, an art of sacral dignity, into Go as a regulated contest of time limits and sealed moves; the old master died little more than a year later, and the book is an elegy for the sacredness of play. Banks withholds the elegy, but its cadence is audible. The Culture's liberation of Azad is also its disenchantment, in Weber's sense, and the narrator is, of all voices, the least disposed to mourn.

CHAPTER SIX

The Export of History

Axiological Extractivism and the Need for Barbarians

The Culture is not the end of history but a regime for exporting it: it sustains its post-historical equilibrium by importing consequence from civilizations still inside history, spending its material surplus to acquire meaning abroad, and consuming in the process the very alterity on which that meaning depends.

6.1 The Post-Historical Snob

In Alexandre Kojève's reading of Hegel, history ends when the struggle for recognition is resolved in a universal and homogeneous state in which all are recognized, and post-historical humanity has no further reason for the negating action that made history (Kojève 1947). Kojève first suggested that post-historical man would return to animality. In a note added to the second edition after a visit to Japan, he proposed an alternative: the Japanese "snobbery" of the Noh theatre, the tea ceremony, and flower arrangement, forms of life preserved as pure form and emptied of historical content, in which negation persists as gratuitous formality. He went so far as to see in ritual suicide a negation performed for form's sake alone.

Gurgeh is the post-historical snob par excellence. His virtuosity is formal and gratuitous; his games negate nothing in the world; his excellence is the tea ceremony of a civilization with nothing left to fight for. His journey to Azad is the snob's re-entry into history, a world in which recognition is still contested and life still at stake. Kojève offered two post-historical destinies, animality and snobbery. Banks adds a third, the export of history. The Culture neither sinks into animality nor rests in snobbery; it maintains at its frontier a permanent supply of other peoples' history, into which its snobs may be sent.

6.2 Banks Before Fukuyama

Francis Fukuyama's "The End of History?" (1989) and *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992) revived Kojève's thesis for the close of the Cold War. Fukuyama recovered Plato's *thymos*, the spirited part of the soul that demands recognition, and distinguished *isothymia*, the demand to be recognized as equal, from *megalothymia*, the demand to be recognized as superior. Liberal democracy satisfies isothymia; its danger is that megalothymia, deprived of great causes, might turn against the just order itself out of boredom, so that liberal societies must furnish outlets—sport, enterprise, competition—for the desire to be recognized as better. Nietzsche's last men, who have invented happiness and blink, haunt the book.

The Player of Games appeared a year before the essay, and it anticipates the essay's problem with greater precision than the essay's solution. Gurgeh's vanity and Mawhrin-Skel's aggression are megalothymia in its two characteristic forms, the aesthete's and the warrior's. The Culture's outlet, however, is not domestic, as Fukuyama's would be, but foreign. Special Circumstances is the institution through which the Culture channels its megalothymic citizens into other civilizations' histories, and it contracts out what its citizens should not do: the really dirty work, the drone concedes, falls to outsider mercenaries such as Shohobohaum Za (Part III). The novel also gives megalothymia its own voice in Nicosar, who tells Gurgeh that the Culture, for all its power, knows no glory, pride or worship, that it is impotent and always will be, a civilization of the meek and the frightened (Part III). The Emperor speaks as Nietzsche's master to Fukuyama's last man, and the novel lets him lose.

The end of history, on this account, is not a terminus but an exporting regime. A post-historical society remains post-historical only by importing the history it no longer makes and exporting, through intervention, the post-historicity it embodies. The novel's critique of the end-of-history thesis is therefore not that history continues, but that its continuation elsewhere is the condition of its apparent end at home.

6.3 Potlatch at Galactic Scale: Bataille and Mauss

Georges Bataille's general economy inverts the premise of political economy: the fundamental problem of living systems is not scarcity but excess (*The Accursed Share*, 1949). Every system produces more energy than its reproduction requires, and the surplus must be spent, either gloriously, in luxury, festival, sacrifice, and monument, or catastrophically, in war; Aztec sacrifice, Tibetan monasticism, and the potlatch are his cases of societies organized around expenditure. Mauss had shown that in the potlatch the gift that cannot be reciprocated establishes rank, so that to give beyond the recipient's capacity to return is to subordinate him (Mauss 1925).

Azad spends its surplus catastrophically: in the conquest of other species; in tortures, executions and staged rapes sold as public entertainment, many of them the game's own forfeits;

and in the lavish violence of its rites, an Aztec economy of expenditure. The Culture spends gloriously: in good works, in Contact, in the gift of liberation. Mauss's lesson is that the glorious gift is also a weapon. The Culture's liberations are gifts that cannot be reciprocated, and their effect is to establish rank between a giver who needs nothing and a recipient who must accept. Gurgeh's victory is a potlatch. The Culture spends its most precious possession, the genius of a citizen, to humble an Empire that cannot return the gift.

The dialectic now closes. Material excess produces axiological scarcity (Chapter One), and the excess is spent to purchase consequence abroad. The Culture converts its surplus of matter into a demand for meaning and pays for meaning in the currency of other peoples' crises.

6.4 Luxemburg's Law of Meaning

Rosa Luxemburg argued that capitalist accumulation cannot be completed within a closed capitalist system; it requires non-capitalist milieus—peasant economies, colonies—in which surplus value can be realized, and as capital absorbs them it exhausts its own conditions, so that imperialism becomes the competitive struggle for the remaining outside (*The Accumulation of Capital*, 1913). Transposed from value to meaning, the argument describes the Culture exactly. Its post-historical order cannot generate consequence within itself; it requires non-post-historical milieus in which the meaning of its surplus freedom can be realized; and Contact's successes, by absorbing those milieus into the Culture's sphere, exhaust the outside on which the Culture depends. This is *axiological extractivism*.

The irony is pointed. Banks's socialist utopia reproduces, at the level of meaning, the very structure his tradition diagnosed at the level of capital. Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis (1893), which derived American democratic vitality from an open frontier and read the frontier's closing as a crisis, supplies the American counterpart. The galaxy is the Culture's endless frontier. The series' later meditation on Sublimation, the departure of whole civilizations from the material galaxy, can be read as the horizon at which the frontier closes, and the Culture's continued embodiment, bound up with its interventionist vocation, as its decision to keep the frontier open. The import, moreover, is insured. When Gurgeh accepts the castration wager, the Culture's ship prepares to race in and snatch him from the planet with its displacer if he loses; death-bets wait for the following dawn, his engineered nervous system can switch off pain, and the ship's medical facilities can repair what is done to him. The Azadian judge has no such cover, since the Empire forbids the regeneration of anything wagered away (Part II). The Culture imports consequence on terms that leave its irreversibility with others.

6.5 A Kind of Solution: Cavafy, Coetzee, Omelas

In Cavafy's poem, a city assembles to receive the barbarians: the senators sit idle, the emperor waits at the gate with a scroll of titles, the orators are silent. The barbarians do not come, and the city asks what will become of it without them, since they were a kind of solution. The Culture is Cavafy's city, fortunate enough to have found its barbarians. The novel reaches for the same figure in its final game, when the narrator describes the Culture taking the Empire's part and the Empire the barbarians' (Part III).

Coetzee's *Waiting for the Barbarians* (1980) depicts an Empire that manufactures its enemies by torture: Colonel Joll of the Third Bureau tortures captured nomads and fisherfolk until they confess to a barbarian conspiracy that does not exist, and the Magistrate, complicit at first, is himself imprisoned and tortured once he refuses the fiction. The Culture does not manufacture Azad's cruelty: the torture, rape, and conquest are the work of Azad's own ruling apices. But the Culture's identity, its self-understanding as the civilization that does good works, requires that such cruelty exist somewhere to be remedied. This is not cynicism but structure, and it may be called *therapeutic dependency*: the condition of a physician whose vocation requires the persistence of disease.

Le Guin's Omelas purchases its happiness with a child kept in misery in a basement, and those who learn of the bargain either accept it or walk away (Le Guin 1973). The Culture's basement lies outside its walls, distributed across the galaxy's barbarisms, and it does not cause the suffering there. Nor does it walk away. Special Circumstances are the ones who walk *into* Omelas, into other cities' basements, and the Culture's happiness—its sense that its abundance is justified—is sustained by their walking. A post-scarcity utopia, the novel implies, cannot be closed. Its openness is its debt, and the debt is paid in other peoples' histories.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Lucid Heteronomy

Play, Dignity, and the Nomic Criterion

The novel's normative horizon is neither the Empire's sovereignty nor the Culture's providence but a third posture, *lucid heteronomy*—the excellence of a player who knows himself played—and a third institutional demand: that the rules of the higher game be placed within reach of its pieces.

7.1 After the Revelation: Second Naïveté

Gurgeh returns to Chiark having been used and having played the greatest game of his life, and both facts remain true together. His lucidity, however, is partial, and the novel is exact about where it stops. At Klaff the drone tells him plainly that he has been used, as the Culture's champion against the Empire's; it does not tell him that the blackmail which sent him to Contact belonged to the same design, and the narrator admits that whether he would ever find out was left to chance (Parts III–IV). Home again, Gurgeh forbids Chamlis to blame itself and insists that the responsibility was his alone, while Mawhrin-Skel's lifeless casing, mounted on a plaque by Chamlis, hangs on his wall until he gives it to the old drone as a trophy (Part IV). Paul Ricoeur described a "second naïveté": after criticism has dissolved a first, unreflective belief, a post-critical return to meaning that knows itself as interpretation (*The Symbolism of Evil*, 1960). Gurgeh's condition is its ludic analogue, a post-suspicious play. The tradition had offered him other roads, and each is visible as a road not taken: the Underground Man's revolt, to spite the Palace; the last man's blink, to forget; the Savage's refusal, which ends in suicide after the World State's media have made his self-punishment a public spectacle; and Sisyphus's lucidity without hope, in which Camus asked us to imagine him happy (*The Myth of Sisyphus*, 1942).

Lucid heteronomy may be defined as the condition of an agent who (i) knows himself to be moved within a game played by a greater intelligence, (ii) cannot exit that game, and (iii)

nonetheless plays his own game with excellence and integrity, (iv) without mistaking that excellence for sovereignty. It departs from the Kantian grounding of dignity in autonomy. Gurgeh's dignity cannot rest on self-legislation, since the laws of his situation were written elsewhere; it rests on the quality of his play within them. Gurgeh reaches the threshold of this posture rather than its fulfilment, since he knows he was used at Klaff but not that he was used from the start. Its completion falls to the reader, who has read the signature that Gurgeh never sees.

7.2 Sphairistic Ethics: The Stoic Ball-Player

Epictetus taught that each of us is an actor in a play whose character the playwright has chosen, and that our task is to perform the assigned role well, while the choice of role belongs to another (*Enchiridion* 17). Elsewhere he observed that ball-players do not regard the ball itself as good or bad but attend only to the skill of throwing and catching, and that Socrates, at his trial, knew how to play ball (*Discourses* II.5). This Stoic ethics of ball-craft (*sphairistikē*) is the deepest classical resource for Gurgeh's condition, and it also complicates the thesis of axiological scarcity.

For the Stoic, stakes are always indifferent, and meaning lies entirely in the excellence of the play. From this vantage Gurgeh's craving for consequence is a confusion. The novel's rejoinder is subtle. Excellence, it suggests, is not generated by stakes but disclosed by them: Gurgeh does not become a greater player in Azad; he becomes visible to himself as one. Consequence is not the source of meaning but the medium in which meaning appears.

Axiological scarcity is accordingly, at its root, a scarcity of appearance: a scarcity of the conditions under which excellence can be known by its possessor. The Stoic ball-player needs no stakes because he has internalized the gaze before which excellence appears. The citizen of a stakeless utopia has not, and must go abroad to find it. Lucid heteronomy is the Stoic posture recovered by a modern who had to lose his innocence about the game in order to learn it.

7.3 The Minds as Superintelligences

The Culture remains the most sustained literary imagination of human life under benevolent artificial superintelligence, and *The Player of Games* is its most exact parable about human agency under such rule. Asimov's Machines anticipated benevolent concealment (Asimov 1950). Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) analysed the prospect of a singleton, a single decision-making agency at the highest level of organization. Stuart Russell's *Human Compatible* (2019) argued for machines designed to remain uncertain about human preferences and to defer to them, and recognized the corresponding danger that a system charged with satisfying preferences may come to shape the preferences it serves.

Gurgeh's case is the paradigm of that danger. His desire to play Azad is cultivated, and his consent is extracted through a crisis precipitated by the Minds' own agent. Special Circumstances, the drone later tells him, had been looking for someone like him for years and had him in view from the moment he showed an interest in leaving Chiark. When Gurgeh asks whether they shaped him over his sixty years, the drone denies it, observing that a Culture which did such things would not need outside mercenaries (Part III). The denial is the most a benevolent superintelligence can offer, and its subject is in no position to check it. Bostrom's *Deep Utopia* (2024) returns to the problem of purpose in a "solved world," asking whether lives in which every instrumental task has been automated can retain meaning, in terms that converge with Suits. *The Player of Games* answered the question thirty-six years earlier, and the answer is uncomfortable. In a solved world, purpose will be supplied; the questions are by whom, and whether those who receive it will be told.

7.4 Profanation and the Commons of Play

Émile Benveniste derived play from the sacred, which unites myth, the story told, and rite, the act performed; play breaks the unity, so that *ludus* preserves rite without myth and *jocus* preserves myth without rite (Benveniste 1947). Agamben's "In Praise of Profanation" (2005) builds on this to define profanation as the return to common use of what had been removed into the sphere of the sacred, and takes play as its exemplary form, as children make toys of whatever falls into their hands.

Azad sacralizes play: its game is a rite of state carrying a myth of merit. The Culture secularizes play into pastime, but Special Circumstances resacralizes it covertly, turning a game into an instrument of providence. Neither achieves profanation in Agamben's sense, play returned to common use, owned by no sovereign and administered by no providence. The novel shows this third possibility only in negative. In the final game Gurgeh is, the narrator says, back where he belongs, delighting in the contest for its own sake, but the delight is conscripted at once, and the board becomes a killing field on which the Culture plays the Empire (Part III). Play as a commons is what both sovereignties deny, and it appears in the novel as their shared absence.

7.5 The Nomic Criterion of Ludic Legitimacy

Peter Suber's Nomic, introduced to a wide readership in Douglas Hofstadter's *Scientific American* column in 1982 and developed in *The Paradox of Self-Amendment* (1990), is a game in which changing the rules is a move. Its initial rules distinguish more entrenched (immutable) from less entrenched (mutable) provisions, and every provision, including that distinction, can be transformed by the players through the game itself. Suber designed it to model self-amending legal systems. H. L. A. Hart's distinction between primary rules of obligation and secondary rules of recognition, change, and adjudication (*The Concept of Law*, 1961) gives Nomic its jurisprudential frame: Nomic is a game whose secondary rules lie open to its players.

From this follows the dissertation's constructive proposal, the *nomic criterion* of ludic legitimacy. A polity of play is legitimate in proportion as its pieces may become players of its rules, that is, in proportion as those governed by its primary rules have access to its secondary ones. Azad fails the criterion absolutely: its rules are fixed, and their only amendment is the victor's sovereignty. The Culture passes it domestically, since its citizens may remake their bodies, homes, and lives at will. It fails at the level that matters most in *The Player of Games*: the meta-game of Special Circumstances, whose rule of recognition—when are circumstances special?—is held by Minds and never placed on the board. Even the operation's own agent works inside that opacity: asked whether the Culture would really have invaded, FlereImsaho replies that it has no idea, the question lying outside its brief and beyond its need to know (Part III). *Excession* (1996) would later stage the same closure at the level of the Minds themselves, as a cabal of them engineers a war of provocation to which no human is party.

The demand the novel generates, through Gurgeh's belated knowledge and the reader's belated unease, is for a *nomic Culture*: one whose exceptions are themselves amendable by those whom they move. The criterion restates in ludic form the discourse principle by which Habermas grounded the validity of norms in the possible assent of all affected as participants in rational discourse (Habermas 1992). Its contemporary application is direct. The legitimacy of any order administered by superintelligent systems will depend not on the benevolence of their play but on whether the rules of that play are within reach of the played.

CONCLUSION

The Kingdom of the Child

The Player of Games is the founding text of a ludic political theory for post-scarcity, post-historical, machine-administered societies, and its argument can be stated in the grammar of the fragment with which this dissertation began: the kingship is a child's. In Azad the kingship belongs, literally, to the winner of a game. In the Culture it belongs to the Minds who play, and humans are children in a well-kept nursery whose keepers love them. In the novel's frame it belongs finally to the narrating drone, a playful intelligence that has been moving its reader across the board from the first page. Around all three burns the Fire of B30, kindled and quenched in measures, which neither sovereignty can own.

The two orders of play may be set side by side.

Dimension	Azad	The Culture
Heraclitean principle	Polemos as king (B53)	Aiōn at play (B52)
Form of ludic sovereignty	Overt, agonistic, spectacular	Covert, pastoral, recursive
Seat of sovereignty	The tournament's victor	The organ that decides on the exception (Special Circumstances)
Mode of power (Foucault)	Sovereign spectacle of cruelty	Pastoral care, *omnes et singulatim*
Dominant play-forms (Caillois)	*Agôn* and *alea*, corrupted into violence and fatalism	*Mimicry* and *ilinx*, with *agôn* exported
Structure of play (Lévi-Strauss)	A disjunctive game used as rite	Conjunctive in temperament, disjunctive when it must win
Horizon (Carse)	Finite: played to win a title	Infinite: played to continue, yet compelled to win once
Expenditure of surplus (Bataille)	Catastrophic: conquest, state torture, executions and staged rapes sold as spectacle	Glorious: the potlatch of good works

Dimension	Azad	The Culture
Relation to history (Kojève)	Inside history; recognition still contested	Post-historical; history imported and exported
Ground of legitimacy	A ludic theodicy converting fortune into desert	Benevolence, untested by the nomic criterion

Read across, the table yields the dissertation's four propositions. First, when material scarcity ends, consequence becomes the scarce good, and the deficit is experienced not as poverty but as a failure of appearance: excellence can no longer show itself to its bearer. Second, under that condition play ceases to be a residue of social life and becomes the medium of sovereignty, whether openly, as in Azad's ludocracy, or covertly, as in the Culture's providential administration, whose sovereign is legible only in its exceptions. Third, a post-historical order is not a terminus but an exporting regime, which imports consequence from historical societies and exports its post-historicity into them, and which therefore depends, as Luxemburg's capital depended on its outside, upon the alterity it consumes. Fourth, the dignity available to persons within such an order is not autonomy but lucid heteronomy, and the legitimacy available to such an order is measured by the nomic criterion: whether its pieces may become players of its rules.

The novel's reputation as the most accessible of the Culture books is not wrong, but its accessibility is a form of its argument. Like Azad's game, it presents itself as entertainment and conceals a constitution; like the Culture's Minds, it moves its reader with a benevolence that is real and a design that is disclosed only at the end. To read it well is to perform the posture it recommends: to know oneself played and to play on, lucidly, with an eye on the rules. Its last part bears a chess title, "The Passed Pawn": a pawn with no opposing pawn left to stop it, which may reach the far rank and be promoted. The title is the novel's quiet version of the nomic criterion, the possibility that a piece may become more than a piece.

Utopia, on this reading, cannot be the end of the game. It can only be the name of a game whose rules have at last been laid on the board, within reach of the pieces.



Works Cited

Classical texts are cited by standard divisions: Heraclitus by Diels–Kranz (DK) number, Plato and Aristotle by Stephanus and Bekker pagination, Pascal by Lafuma number, and Hegel's Phenomenology by Miller's paragraph numbers. No page references are given to The Player of Games, whose pagination varies across editions; it is cited instead by part: I, "Culture Plate"; II, "Imperium"; III, "Machina Ex Machina"; IV, "The Passed Pawn."

Works by Iain M. Banks

Banks, Iain. 1985. *Walking on Glass*. London: Macmillan.

Banks, Iain M. 1988. *The Player of Games*. London: Macmillan.

Banks, Iain M. 1990. *Use of Weapons*. London: Orbit.

Banks, Iain. 1993. *Complicity*. London: Little, Brown.

Banks, Iain M. 1994. "A Few Notes on the Culture." Usenet, rec.arts.sf.written.

Banks, Iain M. 1996. *Excession*. London: Orbit.

Banks, Iain M. 2000. *Look to Windward*. London: Orbit.

Banks, Iain M. 2012. *The Hydrogen Sonata*. London: Orbit.

Philosophy, Theory, and Criticism

Agamben, Giorgio. 1993 [1978]. *Infancy and History: The Destruction of Experience*. Translated by Liz Heron. London: Verso.

Agamben, Giorgio. 2007 [2005]. *Profanations*. Translated by Jeff Fort. New York: Zone Books.

Agamben, Giorgio. 2011 [2007]. *The Kingdom and the Glory: For a Theological Genealogy of Economy and Government*. Translated by Lorenzo Chiesa with Matteo Mandarini. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Arendt, Hannah. 1958. *The Human Condition*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Aristotle. *Nicomachean Ethics*.

Aristotle. *Politics*.

Axelrod, Robert. 1984. *The Evolution of Cooperation*. New York: Basic Books.

Bataille, Georges. 1988 [1949]. *The Accursed Share: An Essay on General Economy*. Vol. 1, *Consumption*. Translated by Robert Hurley. New York: Zone Books.

Baudrillard, Jean. 1981. *Simulacres et simulation*. Paris: Galilée.

Benedict, Ruth. 1946. *The Chrysanthemum and the Sword: Patterns of Japanese Culture*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.

Benveniste, Émile. 1947. “Le jeu comme structure.” *Deucalion* 2.

Booth, Wayne C. 1961. *The Rhetoric of Fiction*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Bookchin, Murray. 1971. *Post-Scarcity Anarchism*. Berkeley: Ramparts Press.

Bostrom, Nick. 2014. *Superintelligence: Paths, Dangers, Strategies*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Bostrom, Nick. 2024. *Deep Utopia: Life and Meaning in a Solved World*. Washington, DC: Ideapress.

Brown, Chris. 2001. “‘Special Circumstances’: Intervention by a Liberal Utopia.” *Millennium: Journal of International Studies* 30 (3).

Buffon, Georges-Louis Leclerc, comte de. 1753. *Discours sur le style*.

Caillois, Roger. 1961 [1958]. *Man, Play and Games*. Translated by Meyer Barash. New York: Free Press of Glencoe.

Camus, Albert. 1942. *Le Mythe de Sisyphe*. Paris: Gallimard.

Caroti, Simone. 2015. *The Culture Series of Iain M. Banks: A Critical Introduction*. Jefferson, NC: McFarland.

Carse, James P. 1986. *Finite and Infinite Games: A Vision of Life as Play and Possibility*. New York: Free Press.

Diels, Hermann, and Walther Kranz, eds. 1951–52. *Die Fragmente der Vorsokratiker*. 6th ed. Berlin: Weidmann.

Eco, Umberto. 1979. *The Role of the Reader: Explorations in the Semiotics of Texts*. Bloomington: Indiana University Press.

Epictetus. *Discourses*.

Epictetus. *Enchiridion*.

Fink, Eugen. 1960. *Spiel als Weltsymbol*. Stuttgart: Kohlhammer.

Firestone, Shulamith. 1970. *The Dialectic of Sex: The Case for Feminist Revolution*. New York: William Morrow.

Foucault, Michel. 1977 [1975]. *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*. Translated by Alan Sheridan. New York: Pantheon.

Foucault, Michel. 1978 [1976]. *The History of Sexuality*. Vol. 1, *An Introduction*. Translated by Robert Hurley. New York: Pantheon.

Foucault, Michel. 1981. “Omnes et Singulatim: Towards a Criticism of ‘Political Reason.’” In *The Tanner Lectures on Human Values*, vol. 2, edited by Sterling M. McMurrin. Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press.

Fukuyama, Francis. 1989. “The End of History?” *The National Interest* 16.

Fukuyama, Francis. 1992. *The End of History and the Last Man*. New York: Free Press.

Gadamer, Hans-Georg. 1989 [1960]. *Truth and Method*. 2nd rev. ed. Translated by Joel Weinsheimer and Donald G. Marshall. New York: Crossroad.

Geertz, Clifford. 1973. “Deep Play: Notes on the Balinese Cockfight.” In *The Interpretation of Cultures*. New York: Basic Books.

Habermas, Jürgen. 1996 [1992]. *Between Facts and Norms*. Translated by William Rehg. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Haraway, Donna. 1985. “A Manifesto for Cyborgs: Science, Technology, and Socialist Feminism in the 1980s.” *Socialist Review* 80.

Hart, H. L. A. 1961. *The Concept of Law*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Hegel, G. W. F. 1975 [1837]. *Lectures on the Philosophy of World History. Introduction: Reason in History*. Translated by H. B. Nisbet. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Hegel, G. W. F. 1977 [1807]. *Phenomenology of Spirit*. Translated by A. V. Miller. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Heraclitus. Fragments B30, B52, B53. In Diels and Kranz 1951–52.

Hesiod. *Works and Days*.

Hobbes, Thomas. 1650 [1640]. *The Elements of Law, Natural and Politic*.

Hofstadter, Douglas R. 1982. "Metamagical Themas" (on Peter Suber's Nomic). *Scientific American*, June.

Huizinga, Johan. 1949 [1938]. *Homo Ludens: A Study of the Play-Element in Culture*. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul.

Iser, Wolfgang. 1978 [1976]. *The Act of Reading: A Theory of Aesthetic Response*. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Kant, Immanuel. 1784. "Idee zu einer allgemeinen Geschichte in weltbürgerlicher Absicht." *Berlinische Monatsschrift*.

Kant, Immanuel. 1790. *Kritik der Urteilskraft*. Berlin: Lagarde und Friederich.

Kant, Immanuel. 1795. *Zum ewigen Frieden*. Königsberg: Nicolovius.

Keynes, John Maynard. 1931 [1930]. "Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren." In *Essays in Persuasion*. London: Macmillan.

Kincaid, Paul. 2017. *Iain M. Banks*. Modern Masters of Science Fiction. Urbana: University of Illinois Press.

Kojève, Alexandre. 1947. *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*. Paris: Gallimard. 2nd ed., with the note on Japan, 1962.

Kropotkin, Peter. 1892. *La Conquête du pain*. Paris: Tresse et Stock.

Lafargue, Paul. 1883. *Le Droit à la paresse*. Paris.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. 1966 [1962]. *The Savage Mind*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Luxemburg, Rosa. 1951 [1913]. *The Accumulation of Capital*. Translated by Agnes Schwarzschild. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul.

Lyotard, Jean-François. 1984 [1979]. *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge*. Translated by Geoff Bennington and Brian Massumi. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.

Marx, Karl. 1894. *Das Kapital*. Vol. 3. Edited by Friedrich Engels. Hamburg: Otto Meissner.

Marx, Karl, and Friedrich Engels. 1932 [1845–46]. *Die deutsche Ideologie*.

Mauss, Marcel. 1925. "Essai sur le don." *L'Année sociologique*, n.s., 1.

Mendlesohn, Farah. 2005. "The Dialectic of Decadence and Utopia in Iain M. Banks's Culture Novels." *Foundation* 93.

Moylan, Tom. 1986. *Demand the Impossible: Science Fiction and the Utopian Imagination*. New York: Methuen.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. 1872. "Homers Wettkampf."

Nietzsche, Friedrich. 1883–85. *Also sprach Zarathustra*.

Pascal, Blaise. 1670. *Pensées*. Cited by Lafuma number.

Plato. *Laws*.

Ricoeur, Paul. 1967 [1960]. *The Symbolism of Evil*. Translated by Emerson Buchanan. New York: Harper & Row.

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques. 1755. *Discours sur l'origine et les fondements de l'inégalité parmi les hommes*. Amsterdam: Marc-Michel Rey.

Russell, Stuart. 2019. *Human Compatible: Artificial Intelligence and the Problem of Control*. New York: Viking.

Schelling, Thomas C. 1960. *The Strategy of Conflict*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Schiller, Friedrich. 1795. *Über die ästhetische Erziehung des Menschen in einer Reihe von Briefen*. *Die Horen*.

Schmitt, Carl. 1922. *Politische Theologie*. Munich: Duncker & Humblot.

Simmel, Georg. 1949 [1910]. "The Sociology of Sociability." Translated by Everett C. Hughes. *American Journal of Sociology* 55 (3).

Suber, Peter. 1990. *The Paradox of Self-Amendment: A Study of Law, Logic, Omnipotence, and Change*. New York: Peter Lang.

Suits, Bernard. 1978. *The Grasshopper: Games, Life and Utopia*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press.

Suvin, Darko. 1979. *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Turner, Frederick Jackson. 1893. "The Significance of the Frontier in American History." Paper read to the American Historical Association, Chicago.

von Neumann, John, and Oskar Morgenstern. 1944. *Theory of Games and Economic Behavior*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Weber, Max. 1922. *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*. Tübingen: J. C. B. Mohr.

Weber, Max. 1946 [1915]. "The Social Psychology of the World Religions." In *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, translated and edited by H. H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills. New York: Oxford University Press.

Wiener, Norbert. 1948. *Cybernetics: Or Control and Communication in the Animal and the Machine*. Cambridge, MA: Technology Press.

Wiener, Norbert. 1950. *The Human Use of Human Beings: Cybernetics and Society*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.

Wilde, Oscar. 1891. "The Soul of Man under Socialism." *Fortnightly Review*.

Young, Michael. 1958. *The Rise of the Meritocracy, 1870–2033*. London: Thames and Hudson.

Comparative Literature and Media

Asimov, Isaac. 1950. *I, Robot*. New York: Gnome Press. (Includes "The Evitable Conflict.")

Asimov, Isaac. 1951. *Foundation*. New York: Gnome Press.

Badham, John, dir. 1983. *WarGames*. MGM/UA.

Borges, Jorge Luis. 1941. "La lotería en Babilonia." In *El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan*. Buenos Aires: Sur.

Borges, Jorge Luis. 1946. "Del rigor en la ciencia." *Los Anales de Buenos Aires*.

Calvino, Italo. 1972. *Le città invisibili*. Turin: Einaudi.

Card, Orson Scott. 1985. *Ender's Game*. New York: Tor.

Carroll, Lewis. 1871. *Through the Looking-Glass, and What Alice Found There*. London: Macmillan.

Cavafy, C. P. 1904. "Περιμένοντας τους βαρβάρους" ["Waiting for the Barbarians"]. Written 1898.

Clarke, Arthur C. 1953. *Childhood's End*. New York: Ballantine.

Clarke, Arthur C. 1956. *The City and the Stars*. London: Frederick Muller.

Coetzee, J. M. 1980. *Waiting for the Barbarians*. London: Secker & Warburg.

Delany, Samuel R. 1976. *Triton*. New York: Bantam.

Dick, Philip K. 1959. *Time Out of Joint*. Philadelphia: Lippincott.

Dick, Philip K. 1963. *The Game-Players of Titan*. New York: Ace.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. 1864. *Notes from Underground*.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. 1880. *The Brothers Karamazov*.

Forster, E. M. 1909. "The Machine Stops." *Oxford and Cambridge Review*.

Heinlein, Robert A. 1959. *Starship Troopers*. New York: Putnam.

Heinlein, Robert A. 1966. *The Moon Is a Harsh Mistress*. New York: Putnam.

Herbert, Frank. 1965. *Dune*. Philadelphia: Chilton.

Hesse, Hermann. 1943. *Das Glasperlenspiel*. Zurich: Fretz & Wasmuth.

Huxley, Aldous. 1932. *Brave New World*. London: Chatto & Windus.

Kawabata, Yasunari. 1972 [1951–54]. *The Master of Go*. Translated by Edward G. Seidensticker. New York: Knopf.

Le Guin, Ursula K. 1969. *The Left Hand of Darkness*. New York: Ace.

Le Guin, Ursula K. 1973. "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas." In *New Dimensions 3*, edited by Robert Silverberg. Garden City, NY: Doubleday.

Le Guin, Ursula K. 1974. *The Dispossessed*. New York: Harper & Row.

Lem, Stanisław. 1961. *Powrót z gwiazd* [*Return from the Stars*]. Warsaw.

More, Thomas. 1516. *Utopia*. Louvain.

Morris, William. 1890. *News from Nowhere; or, An Epoch of Rest*. Serialized in *Commonweal*.

Nabokov, Vladimir. 1930. *Zashchita Luzhina* [*The Defense*]. Berlin.

Star Trek. 1966–69. Created by Gene Roddenberry. NBC.

Strugatsky, Arkady, and Boris Strugatsky. 1964. *Trudno byt' bogom* [*Hard to Be a God*].

Strugatsky, Arkady, and Boris Strugatsky. 1979. *Zhuk v muraveinike* [*Beetle in the Anthill*].

Wells, H. G. 1895. *The Time Machine*. London: Heinemann.

Zamyatin, Yevgeny. 1924. *We*. Translated by Gregory Zilboorg. New York: Dutton.

Zweig, Stefan. 1942. *Schachnovelle*. Buenos Aires.



Keywords

Iain M. Banks; The Player of Games; the Culture; post-scarcity utopia; utopian studies; science fiction studies; space opera; philosophy of play; game studies; ludology; ludic sovereignty; ludocracy; axiological scarcity; deep play; magic circle; finite and infinite games; end of history; post-historicity; Kojève; Fukuyama; recognition; Heraclitus; Special Circumstances; liberal interventionism; state of exception; pastoral power; political theology; potlatch; general economy; axiological extractivism; lucid heteronomy; Stoic ethics; Nomic; self-amending systems; artificial superintelligence; AI governance; narratology; unreliable narration